



BEFORE

Lincoln's election on a sectional basis and on a party platform that aimed to limit slavery, combined with the swift secession of the Lower South, made war nearly inevitable.

SOWING THE SEEDS

The Republicans did not even try to contest elections in ten Southern states, and the Lower South saw any legal restriction on slavery by the Federal government as paving the way for more serious attacks on the institution.

THE LIMITS OF COMPROMISE

A native of Kentucky and admirer of Henry Clay, Lincoln had conciliatory instincts, but he also remained true to the Free-Soil principles of the [Republican Party](#). This, combined with Confederate intransigence, made some kind of violent clash all but unavoidable (see [Abraham Lincoln](#)).

At 4:30 a.m. on April 12, 1861, Confederate batteries around the harbor at Charleston, South Carolina, opened fire on Fort Sumter, a Federal fortification built on a small island at the harbor's mouth. The fort's commander, Major Robert Anderson, began surrender negotiations the next afternoon. Anderson had staunchly maintained the Union position at Fort Sumter since South Carolina's secession the previous December, but the approach of a Union naval squadron with fresh supplies for the fort had provoked a definitive confrontation.

Local Confederate commander P. G. T. Beauregard had been given orders to demand the immediate evacuation of the fort. When Anderson refused, hostilities began, and were concluded without any combat fatalities on either side. While the Confederacy believed the attack to be a necessary and reasonable defense of its sovereignty, most Northerners saw it as an immoral assault on American troops.

The Republican Party had swept the North in the presidential election of 1860, but the Democrats remained a potent political force, with much weaker anti-slavery instincts. However, most Democrats remained loyal Unionists, and the Confederate attack on "Old Glory" (the national flag) at Sumter outraged their nationalist sensibilities, which led to an outpouring of public support for a military campaign to crush secession.

Major Robert Anderson was a Kentuckian and former enslaver, with a stellar record as a leading artillery reformer and in combat in the War with Mexico.